

THE STORY OF WRITING

FROM CAVE PAINTINGS TO THE DIGITAL AGE, WRITING IN ITS VARIOUS FORMS HAS ALWAYS BEEN AN IMPORTANT PART OF OUR CIVILIZATION

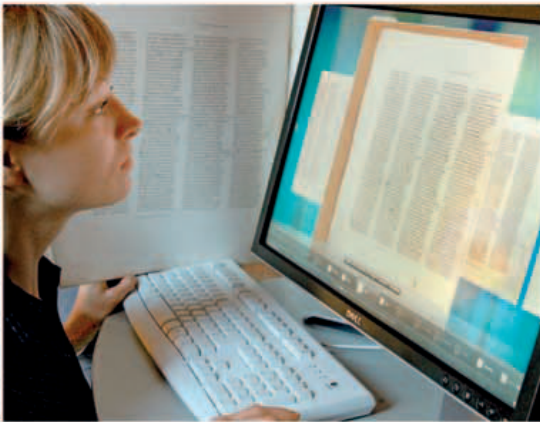
The development of writing was an amazing breakthrough, as it allowed people to communicate over distance and record information for posterity. Writing evolved separately in different cultures: in Mesopotamia, Egypt, and the Indus Valley before 2500 BCE and later in Crete, China, and Mesoamerica.

Some scholars think that prehistoric cave paintings featuring images and symbols constitute a form of writing. The first true script was developed by the Sumerians of Mesopotamia (now Iraq) around 3300 BCE. Soon, a number of different ancient cultures had developed writing, usually to keep economic records or keep track of time. As writing developed, it was commonly used to reinforce the authority of rulers. Many early texts, including monumental ones in stone, glorify the deeds of kings and attribute their success to divine approval.

Writing systems can be divided into three types, according to the function of the signs used: logographic, syllabic, and alphabetic. However, some scripts make use of two types of signs. In logographic scripts, each sign stands for a whole word; Chinese writing is an example, although it also uses syllabic signs. The drawback is that a very large number of symbols are needed (Chinese has 50,000 characters). In syllabic scripts, signs stand for syllables. A smaller but still large number of signs are needed—700 in Babylonian cuneiform. In alphabetic scripts, each sign stands for a sound. Far fewer symbols are needed—usually around 26. The first alphabets developed in the Levant between 1450 and 1150 BCE. For years, the spread of writing was limited by the labor involved in hand-copying texts, but this changed with the invention of printing. In the late 20th century, writing became electronic with the invention of word processors. In the 1990s, the spread of information was again revolutionized by the arrival of the Internet.

Ancient texts in the digital world

Nowadays, ancient texts can be viewed digitally. Here, a student examines a digitized page of the Codex Sinaiticus, handwritten in Greek over 1,600 years ago.



Roman mosaic



Modern sign

PICTOGRAPHIC SYMBOLS

Pictograms, or picture signs, are an ancient form of communication. Some scholars do not consider pictograms to be “true” writing, since the symbols do not convey the sounds of words in any language. For example, the pictures above—from a house in Roman Pompeii dating to 79 CE, and a modern sign—convey the same warning. The symbol can be read in any language—for instance, as *canis*, *chien*, *Hund*, or dog. Those words convey the same idea but reproduce the sounds of different languages—Latin, French, German, and English. Pictograms have limited use but remain widespread, appearing, for example, on street signs, maps, and clothes labels.

7th century Arabic script

The Arabic alphabet is used to write down the Qur'an, the holy book of Islam. Its use spreads with the Islamic faith to become one of the world's most widely used scripts.



Medieval Qur'an

c. 1450

Invention of printing

In medieval times, the laboriousness of copying by hand limits the spread of writing. The invention of printing using movable type makes writing far more accessible. In 1500, an estimated 35,000 texts are in print.



Book of Durrow

1867–1868

The typewriter

American inventor Christopher Latham Sholes helps to build the first practical typewriter. The patent is sold to Remington, which puts the first typewriters on sale in 1874.



The Remington Model I

1884

The fountain pen

The first practical fountain pen is produced by American inventor L. E. Waterman, and quickly replaces the quill pen. Ballpoints, invented by László Bíró, are in use by the 1940s.



Waterman fountain pen

1990–present Text messaging

In the 1990s, the first text messages are sent via mobile phones. Texting becomes very popular in the 2000s. In 2009, more than 1.5 trillion text messages are sent.

Smartphone



4th century The codex

The codex, or manuscript in book form, gradually supersedes the roll of parchment. Originally developed by the Romans, the use of codices spreads with the Christian religion.

7th–9th centuries Illuminated manuscripts

In early medieval times, the use of writing spreads through the copying of Christian texts. Illuminated manuscripts are highly decorative, with ornate capital letters and marginal illustrations.